



MODULE 3

The Coach-Athlete Relationship

How well do your players know you — and how well do you know them?

CORE THEORY

Jowett's 3C+1 model (2007) describes the coach-athlete relationship through four dimensions: Closeness (emotional nearness), Commitment (mutual dedication), Complementarity (working together), and Co-orientation (shared understanding). Research consistently shows that the quality of this relationship is the single strongest predictor of athletic performance, wellbeing, and enjoyment. Athletes perform better for coaches who know them as people, not just as athletes.

Source: Jowett & Ntoumanis (2004) · Jowett (2007) · Lorimer & Jowett (2009)

"Players play for coaches who know them as a person. They play harder for coaches who respect them as a human being."

— John Wooden

"The coach-athlete relationship is the most influential human relationship in sport."

— Sophia Jowett

SELF-REFLECTION

- 1 Do you know about every player on your team: what truly occupies them outside sport? Name one thing per player.
- 2 Which players on your team feel least connected to you? What are you actively doing to change that?
- 3 How do you show commitment to your players — beyond training and games?
- 4 When did a player last share something personal with you? How did you respond?
- 5 How balanced is the relationship: do you invest as much in the quiet, average player as in the star?

NOTES

**BOOKS**

- **The Relationship Coach**
Sophia Jowett & Marc Lafrenière
Why: The definitive work on coach-athlete relationships. Theory translated directly into practice.
- **It's Your Ship**
D. Michael Abrashoff
Why: How a Navy commander transformed his team by truly getting to know every person. Direct translation to sport.
- **The Culture Code**
Daniel Coyle
Why: Three skills that build culture: safety, vulnerability, and shared purpose. The chapter on the All Blacks is a must.

**VIDEO'S / TED TALKS**

- **Building a Psychologically Safe Workplace**
Amy Edmondson (TEDx)
[youtube.com/watch?v=LhoLuui9gX8](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LhoLuui9gX8)
How safety in relationships boosts performance. Directly applicable in team context.
- **Every Kid Needs a Champion**
Rita Pierson (TED Talk)
[ted.com/talks/rita_pierson_every_kid_needs_a_champion](https://www.ted.com/talks/rita_pierson_every_kid_needs_a_champion)
"Kids don't learn from people they don't like." Powerful for youth coaches.

**PODCASTS**

- **Finding Mastery**
Episode with Gregg Popovich — relationship-building as a performance driver
[findingmastery.com](https://www.findingmastery.com)
- **The Coach2 Podcast**
On making individual connection in a team context
[coachingforleaders.com](https://www.coachingforleaders.com)

⚡ ACTION THIS WEEK

Schedule an informal 1-on-1 conversation this week with a player you know least well. No sports agenda — just genuinely listen. Write down what you learn.

One player in whom I will consciously invest more in the relationship:
